



照片提供：人師編輯部

Unit 2: A Street Performer

One day, a man stood outside a temple playing a strange musical instrument. He played non-stop for quite some time and even played when no one was there to listen.

Passersby had mixed reactions to his playing. Some applauded, some simply smiled at him, but others frowned as if they thought he had no business in being there. One little boy took a special interest in the man. The boy watched and listened intently, as only a child could. He was fascinated by how the man could make such beautiful music come from the strange instrument.

After some time, the young boy spoke to the musician, “Excuse me, sir. I am sorry to interrupt, but I was wondering what the instrument you are playing is called.”

“It’s an erhu,” the man told the boy.

“An er who. I’ve never heard of one of those before,” the boy admitted.

“Not an er ‘who’, it is an erhu,” the man calmly said to correct the boy.

“An er what?” the boy asked with a very confused look on his face.

“Erhu, erhu, erhu!” the man exclaimed. He waved his hand in the air in a ‘forget about it’ sort of way and then spoke slowly, “It’s a Chinese violin!”

“Why didn’t you just say that in the first place,” the boy asked.

“Because its real name is an erhu,” the man again explained.

“Huh!” The boy was confused again.

“Get out of here you little punk before I...” the man stopped, took a deep breath and started to play again. He closed his eyes and let his anger dissipate into the happy land of music.

The boy continued to listen for a while, but then lost interest just as quickly as he had gained it. He skipped home and soon he could hear the erhu no more.